

elements of the natural world were central to Celtic beliefs. Oak trees and mistletoe were thought to be sacred. The rituals performed by druids often took place outside, especially in woods.

Celtic art and crafts

Motifs from the natural world are important in Celtic art, too. The Celts were skilled metalworkers and they



Gundestrup cauldron

This Celtic silver vessel was found in a Danish peat bog in 1891. It dates from about the 1st century BCE, and it may have had a ritual purpose.

The Celtic tribes lacked unity and were constantly fighting with each other. Greater, more unified powers subjugated them in most regions.



CARTHAGINIAN COIN, IBERIA

ROMAN RULE

By the 1st century CE, the spread of Roman power had ended Celtic domination in Italy, Gaul (after the Gallic uprising by **Vercingetorix** had been put down), and in England. In northern Italy, Celts had been incorporated as Roman citizens under Caesar **108–09**, who had even raised two legions from this area for his conquest of Gaul. The Romans fought for control of Iberia (Spain),

with the Carthaginians **82–83** and native Celts, although the area remained “Celtiberian,” despite Carthaginian and Roman rule.

GERMANIC VICTORY

Germanic tribes fought against both the Romans and the Celts, and successfully pushed the Celts out of the Rhine Valley.

ON THE MARGINS

Subdued by Roman and Germanic forces, Celtic strongholds were increasingly pushed into the margins of their former lands. Ultimately, they

lingered on for longer in Ireland and other pockets where Celtic culture persists today, such as **Cornwall, Wales,** and the **Scottish Highlands**. It is likely that, during the 4th–6th centuries CE, the Anglo-Saxons further supplanted the Celts in England.



IRISH BROOCH

RISE OF CHRISTIANITY

Christianity reached the non-Roman-ruled Celtic people around the 4th century CE. Celtic churches played an important role in the early spread of the Christian religion in northern Europe.

“The whole Celtic race is obsessed with war.”

STRABO, ANCIENT GREEK HISTORIAN AND GEOGRAPHER, 1ST CENTURY BCE



Warriors on foot with shields and spears, marching toward the left, may be dead soldiers approaching a ritual rebirth in the cauldron.

Musicians blow on long Celtic trumpets. This style of trumpet (*carnyx*) was held vertically and had a mouth shaped like a boar's head. It was played in battle.

spread their knowledge, especially of ironworking techniques, wherever they migrated. Gold and bronze were popular for luxury items—the Celts are famed for wearing gold torcs (neck bands with sculpted ends), as well as bracelets and impressive brooches. They were affected by foreign cultures, too. Some of the geometric and curvilinear shapes in Celtic art were influenced by the various peoples the Celts came into contact with, from the Greeks and Etruscans to steppe people such as the Scythians (see pp.138–39).

Weaponry, war, and dominance

Because a talent for warfare and horsemanship was central to Celtic culture, great artistic skill was poured into weaponry, armor, harnesses, and chariots. Some particularly fine weapons were borne principally as badges of honor and rank, or used for ceremonial purposes rather than in active service. These great warrior-people used shields, swords, and spears as weapons. Some Roman tools of war (such as the *scutum*, a type of shield) reveal Celtic influences. Chariots were used widely in earlier times and skilled horsemanship was greatly prized. Some Celtic tribes painted or tattooed themselves with plant dyes to look more alarming to their enemies.

The Celtic La Tène culture (named after an archaeological site in Switzerland) followed Hallstatt culture (see BEFORE) and grew in influence, becoming dominant between 450–15 BCE. Although it subsequently dwindled, Celtic culture persists today and Celtic languages are still spoken in Brittany (the Breton language), Wales, Scotland, Ireland, and the Isle of Man.

Gundestrup detail

This is one of the panels on the Gundestrup cauldron, decorated with a scene of gods and men. Celtic mythology linked cauldrons with feasting and regeneration, and this particular panel, and the cauldron itself, may echo those beliefs.